‘Here, try this,’ Papaji had come up with one last solution, something Maa had always been reluctant to try.

‘No pacifier, please.’ But even as Maa said this, Papaji put the pacifier between my lips. The tasteless, odourless pacifier worked its magic and I stopped crying at once. Papaji smiled, proud of his victory. ‘She’ll have buck teeth,’ a worried Maa retorted.

‘It’s a myth,’ Papaji replied as he looked at me and made funny faces.

‘But everyone has been warning me.’ Maa wouldn’t let it go. Nevertheless, I was giggling, enjoying myself.

Papaji held me in his arms and replied, ‘Everyone has their own opinion. It may not always be true. Many say it’s not advisable to have a dog while there are infants in the house. But we’ll still have one. Taking care of a dog teaches kids to be responsible. Don’t worry about what everyone says.’ As Papaji said this, he looked into my eyes and repeatedly motioned with his hand, a gesture of throwing the pacifier away. While Maa was still saying something, I did something that startled both of them. I reached for the pacifier and, imitating Papaji’s gesture, threw it away. They both looked at each other, quiet for a moment. Then Papaji picked up the pacifier and gave it to me again. I reached for it and, just like before, threw it away.

‘What just happened?’ Maa whispered.

‘Our daughter just showed us she’s so smart,’ Papaji replied happily and looked at me. ‘You’re so smart, aren’t you?’

‘She agrees with you. She’s a good follower,’ Maa concluded optimistically.

‘I can see that,’ Papaji said as he planted a kiss on my forehead. ‘But I want her to be a good leader too.’

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Papaji would often share moments like these with me. It was as if he wanted to sow some kind of belief in me about myself, an anecdote that might help me when the time came. As I held the question paper of the aptitude test in my hands, I could clearly understand that the time had come.